Elf said there was no point in examining the whys and hows, this was the inalterable rule. The first six in line to the throne had to ask permission. The Royal Marriages Act of 1772, or the Succession to the Crown Act of 2013—he was going on and on and I could barely believe my ears. The point was, love took a decided back seat to law. Indeed, law had trumped love on more than one occasion. A fairly recent relative had been…strongly dissuaded…from marrying the love of their life.

Who?

Your aunt Margaret.

Really?

Yes. She'd wanted to marry a divorcé and…well.

Divorcé?

Elf nodded.

Oh, shit, I thought. This might not be a slam dunk.

But Pa and Camilla were divorcés, I said, and they'd got permission. Didn't that mean the rule no longer applied?

That's them, Elf said. This is you.

To say nothing about the furor over a certain king who'd wanted to marry an American divorcée, which Elf reminded me had ended with the King's abdication and exile. *Duke of Windsor? Ever heard of him?*

And so, heart full of fear, mouth full of dust, I turned to the calendar. With Elf's help I circled a weekend in late October. A family shooting trip at Sandringham. Shooting trips always put Granny in a good mood.

Perhaps she'd be more open to thoughts of love?

33.

CLOUDY, BLUSTERY DAY. I jumped into the venerable old Land Rover, the ancient Army ambulance that Grandpa had repurposed. Pa was behind the wheel, Willy was in the back. I got into the passenger seat and wondered if I should tell them both what I was intending.